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THE VALLEYS OF THE SASKATCHEWAN WITH HORSE AND CAMERA

By Mrs. Charles Schäffer.

Far away in the northland of Canada there lies a vast area of wilderness almost unknown and unvisited. A large portion of it we might designate as muskeg and mosquitoes, and rest content to pass it by. But reaching the vast upheaval—the Rocky Mountains—where lakes and rivers, waterfalls and glaciers have been formed in reckless confusion, there Nature's lover might wander for weeks with the delightful sensation that his was the first human foot to tread the strange by-ways of this land which has been so long an unknown realm save to hunter, trapper and wandering Indian.

The few scientists or pleasure-seekers who have passed the barriers may be counted on the fingers. In 1884, at the completion of that lone line designated as the Canadian Pacific Railroad, the key to the treasure-land of the hills was ready for any who would use it. Since then it has opened the door to lakes, rivers, valleys and mountains which have been but partially explored and named. So vast, however, is the playground that there is always something new for one who lays aside his comforts for the day and finds his pleasure among the hills with his guide, his horse and his camera.

For the past ten years there has been much said, and three or four interesting books written on the Saskatchewan Country, describing the vast mountains and ice-fields in which the river of the same name has its birth. The particular portion which has claimed so much attention lies roughly between latitudes 51 and 52 degrees 30 minutes and longitudes 116 to 118 degrees west.

With a starting point at the little station of Laggan, which lies about eighty miles west of the first rolling foothills of the Rockies, and drawing a straight line at an angle of about 70 degrees from southeast to northwest, one may follow the general trend of the country mentioned. From Laggan direct to the Wilcox Pass no record exists of any other explorer ever making the journey till

FIG 1.—MAP OF THE SASKATCHEWAN VALLEYS.

W. D. Wilcox, of Washington, D. C., passed that way on his trip to the Athabasca in 1896. After him came Dr. J. Norman Collie and Hugh Stutfield, experienced English mountain-climbers, whose charmingly written account, "Climbs and Explorations in the Canadian Rockies," is a valuable book for a student of this region, and to which book I am also indebted for the accompanying sketch-map.

Habel, Fay, Thompson, Noyes and Outram are all names closely associated with the mountains in this particular section, every one of them being keen lovers of the heights, tempted there by the wonderful reports of the greater altitudes of the mountains of the Saskatchewan and Athabasca in comparison with the more southerly and accessible ones.

A number of delightful old books (the first dated as far back as 1801), written by men connected with the old Hudson Bay or Northwest Fur Trading Companies, speak of the well-known highway between the plains of the interior and the Pacific Slope—the Yellow-head and Athabasca Passes, and from thence to the Fraser and Columbia Rivers.

Traversing this route has undoubtedly always been a serious undertaking, as, lying in latitude 54 degrees north, the summers are necessarily short and the winters a trial to test the hardiest constitutions. But, as it was a case of rafts, rivers and heavy loads, there was no other practical way found above the United States boundary.

Thus the far-away pass had been frequently traveled at one time, and it was the intervening space which claimed our attention in the summer of 1906. It was all very well to read of the pleasant days spent by the strong, thoroughly hardened mountaineers among the fastnesses, subsisting on bacon and bannock, with a vision of bear and porcupine steak in case of well laid plans failing, but quite another matter when viewed from our own standpoint.

In spite of croakings and warnings, of bad weather and the lateness of the season, it was on the 28th of August that we viewed our entire outfit from the saddle with great satisfaction and saw it settle down to the trail without one qualm for the luxuries left behind. At the head of the band was a guide who in three years of trailing had never failed us. There are older ones, there are better hunters perhaps, with wider experience in forest lore, more knowledge of the country, but for kindness, good-nature (such a

necessary adjunct), good judgment under unexpected stress, he had no superior.

Our horses had been chosen from the well-known Peyto band —every one sound and in the best condition; and with pride we looked upon the bulging packs containing the food on which we must depend for the next seven weeks. The Canadian Government has included the vast area from the railroad to the Saskatchewan River in a great national park, wisely prohibiting hunting and fishing, thus saving to some extent the fast disappearing game. But this inability to secure game naturally necessitates a much larger supply of provisions to be carried by one passing through so vast a preserve.

From Laggan to the Saskatchewan, during July and August, one usually takes the Pipe-Stone River route to its source, then over the summit of the same name. This pass is about 8,500 feet high, and during the early summer months is a veritable flower garden of Alpine flora. Vetches, the flaming castillea, saxifrages of many varieties, anemones, arnicas and innumerable other plants were found here in the wildest profusion.

On a clear day from the Pipe-Stone summit the view is beyond description. The flowers beneath the feet, the fleecy clouds floating amidst the deep blue, the pure glaciers at our side and the miles and and miles of peaks stretching to north and south, make the thirty-five mile trip well worth while, even if one may go no farther. Crossing the divide, the headwaters of the Siffleur (named for the whistling marmot of this region) greet the eye, and the traveler, behind his slowly moving pack animals, follows it for two days, till in its winding, wandering search, it meets and mingles its clear waters with the muddy, glaciated Saskatchewan.

The Saskatchewan Valley is in its way unique, a kingdom within itself. The Chinook winds of the Pacific, seeming to forget all intervening obstructions, plunge into this narrow space, and thereby govern the climate and many of the natural or physical conditions. Here are found flowers seen nowhere else in our mountain travel, the grasses grow tall and wonderfully luxuriant, horses thrive and fatten, and the Stoney Indians from Morley find it a most excellent health resort—deer, bear, goat and mountain sheep being most acceptable to the Indian constitution.

The valley ranges from three to eight miles in width and is

Fig. 2.—Looking South on the North Fork of Saskatchewan River.

Fig. 3.—Mt. Forbes and Lyall Ice Fields from Junction of Bear Creek and Saskatchewan River.

about eighty miles long. Its curious and charming characteristics were discovered about 1895 by one of the oldest established hunters of the country—Mr. Thomas Wilson—who has since built himself an ideal home there.

He was returning from the North Saskatchewan over the Pipe-Stone Pass with an exploring party when the autumn storms swept down upon him, and he was forced to abandon his horses, reaching Laggan as best he could. Returning in the spring to see if there was anything left of his animals, his surprise may be imagined when he found them fat and well and thoroughly enjoying life in this curious, warm, rich belt of the Saskatchewan.

Considering the lateness of the season in starting and the distance to be covered, the Wilcox Pass was our Mecca. Resting a few days at the Saskatchewan plains, testing the height and power of the waters of that strangely flowing, angry guardian to the northern highway, we found our horses quite equal to fording the now fast diminishing stream, and turned our faces westward to the junction of Bear Creek and the Saskatchewan, a matter of thirty miles.

Reaching this point, we found a never-to-be-forgotten panorama of a gathering of the monarchs of the hills. Mounts Murchison and Wilson, met but for the dividing waters of the Saskatchewan, Pyramid Peak, near Bow Summit, loomed clear and distinct upon the sky-line forty miles to the south, while Sarbach, Forbes, Survey Peak and the Lyall Glacier were ranged across the western horizon.

A day's side trip took us to Glacier Lake, an overflow from the vast Lyall ice fields. Fully five miles in length, green as an emerald, it lay in perfect peace among beautiful surroundings; the tall and stately spruces clung about its shores, while the vast ice tongues from the great Lyall Glacier, glistening in their purity, seemed slowly gliding to their doom in the cold, dark waters below.

But the days of the month were slipping rapidly by, the way was far to go, and provisions have a marvelous way of disappearing under such a strenuous life. The North Fork of the Saskatchewan greeted us with a superb cataract almost at its mouth, a little later the trail was badly marred with fallen timbers from an old forest fire, while near the headwaters was some of the most superb timber we had yet seen. The story of the Invader of Silence could be read

in the ubiquitous tomato and condensed-milk cans seen at intervals on the trail, while here and there tent and tepee-poles marked a good camping ground. One writer of this region tells us that the Indians have some superstition regarding this valley and never visit it for hunting purposes. As old and new tepee-poles, triangularly placed fire-sticks, and well-cleaned goat and sheep bones were found in many desirable camping grounds, there seems some doubt about that statement.

Considering that fair days and warm sunshine had followed our little band for four weeks, one should naturally avoid much grumbling at Fate. Still it seemed hard lines to view the Wilcox Pass in a blanket of mist, to watch the little Sun Wapta, 500 feet below us, flowing to the far-away Athabasca, and apparently dissolving into a low-hanging cloud, to tread the summit of the pass and gaze not upon distant unknown mountain ranges, but on a white woolly blanket, which soon tossed snow and sleet in our faces and forced a retreat.

Leaving the summits to the grip of the coming winter, we retraced our steps to the junction of the North Fork and West Branch, with the merry sunshine mocking our way; and it was with a grain of comfort that we saw the sullen clouds still clustered on the heights as long as they remained in sight. Then down into our next home—Graveyard Camp, came the rain and sleet, an unpropitious omen for our first bit of exploring. At this point we were about to search out a trail directly east to Kline's Creek (an easterly tributary of the Saskatchewan) via Pinto Lake. To our small band of four this region was entirely unknown, and would be so to-day but for the pluck and determination of the guide-in-chief.

There is no record of any previous attempt to take horses and packs across this pass—Indians and a few white hunters alone having been tempted that way for goat and sheep. At the timber-limit stretched a fine park bordered with splendid spruces, while a large number of tepee-poles attested the fact that it was a favorite hunting ground for the fast disappearing red man.

The height at which the horses were eventually taken across was probably about 8,000 feet, being a mere goat-trail not over one foot wide in its most critical point, the rocks covered with a sheet of ice, and any small niche, which might have been useful for a foothold, filled with a dry powdery snow. Should any other aspirant

Fig. 4.—Glacier Lake.

Fig. 5.—House Pass.

ever go that way, let him remember to bear to the left, or, like us, he will be stopped, at the moment he thinks he has reached success, by a wall of rock at least 1,000 feet high.

As we viewed Pinto Lake from that elevation, the sight well repaid us for all the cold and small hardships we had endured to get there. It is well named Pinto (meaning three colors), and is distinctly green, blue and purple. It is about three miles long and half as wide, stocked heavily with speckled trout, while over its surface flew hundreds of Diver-ducks.

Thanks to the skill of our good guides, even the heavily loaded horses reached the lower levels safely. Thus one by one do the fastnesses give up their secrets, and we realize that, with reasonable care, caution and good animals, one may travel almost anywhere in that great wilderness with perfect safety. Kline's Creek is probably named for a "fat, jolly old gentleman" whom Alexander Ross describes thus and speaks of meeting at Jasper House, a Northwest fur trading post in the early days. On the few crude maps to be obtained of that section it bears the name of Cataract Creek, but as there is no visible cataract in its whole length of forty miles, and as there is a very fine one in a small stream which flows into it near its junction with the Saskatchewan, it is undoubtedly one of those mistakes so easy to make in such an untraveled region.

Kline's Valley had little to show our now satiated eyes; forest fires, whether of Indian origin or not, had played havoc everywhere, and we were glad to escape from charred timbers to the golden meadows of the Saskatchewan Valley.

This valley is also called the Kootenai Plains, from its having been the meeting grounds of the Kootenai Indians of the Pacific and the fur-traders from Jasper House. The old, deeply trodden trails still mark the way—all that is left of the happy hunting days when beaver were plenty and even the buffalo found his way to the sheltering hills. Throughout Kline's Valley it was quite common to see the bleaching bones of these animals scattered along the trail, and also the well-defined paths made by these monarchs of the plains when seeking shelter from the wintry blasts among the thick spruces.

For us, too, the breath of the north would soon be blowing, the Stoney Indians were now gathering in large numbers near the spot on the Saskatchewan which we had called "home," and, though

the glamour of the Indian will probably always remain with us to some extent, there is a too great friendliness about him which breeds a love of distance. He, however, retains much of the picturesque, and while we longed to use the camera indiscriminately he had an equal desire to possess our fast-diminishing store of bacon, and it seemed wise to hurry away to the south and to the land of bread and butter.

By October the Pipe-Stone Summit becomes inaccessible except on snowshoes, and then the Bow Pass—6,500 feet high—becomes most practicable. At its summit Bear Creek has its rise, while the well-known Bow River flows from its southern slope.

These two valleys are a fitting close to a summer's journey among the hills. Rivers, lakes, mountains and glaciers follow each other in a wild riot of glorious beauty, as though luring one to stay, then, grown petulant with the traveler's determination to still continue on his way, casts before his feet for twelve long weary miles a mass of the most trying fallen timbers.

Then comes the railroad into sight, a good hotel and prosy comforts—the summer's days have passed. The aromatic bough beds, our loved horses, the evening camp-fires, the twinkling stars by night, the bright sunshine by day, the soft sweet balsam-laden air are behind us: the roar of a great city comes to me as I write—it seems but a dream.

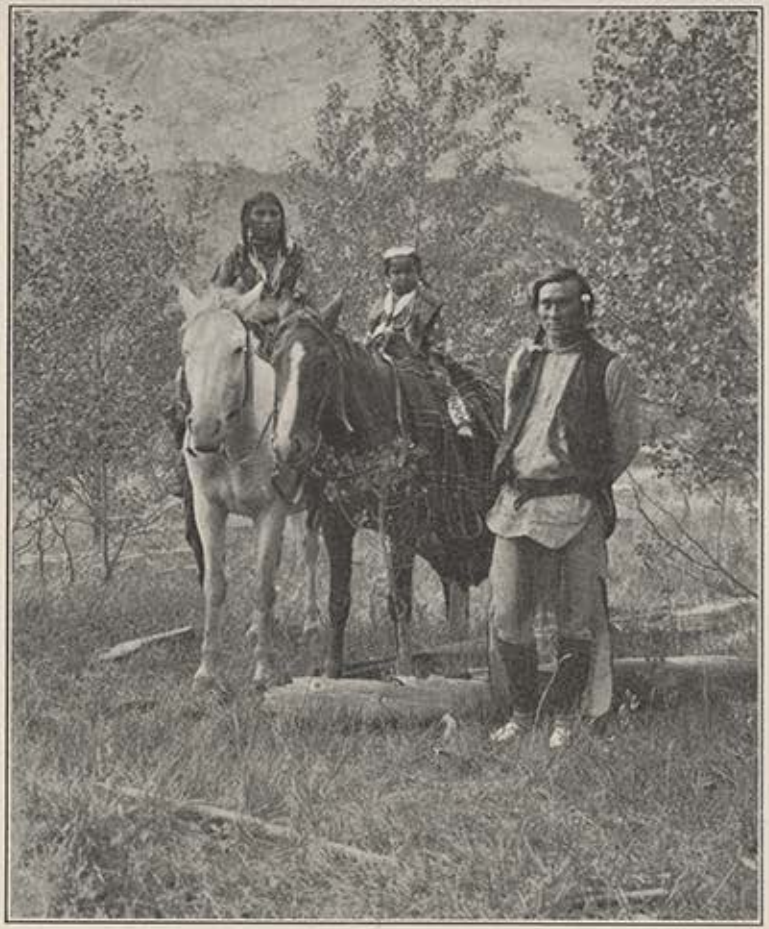

Fig. 6.—A Stoney Indian Family.

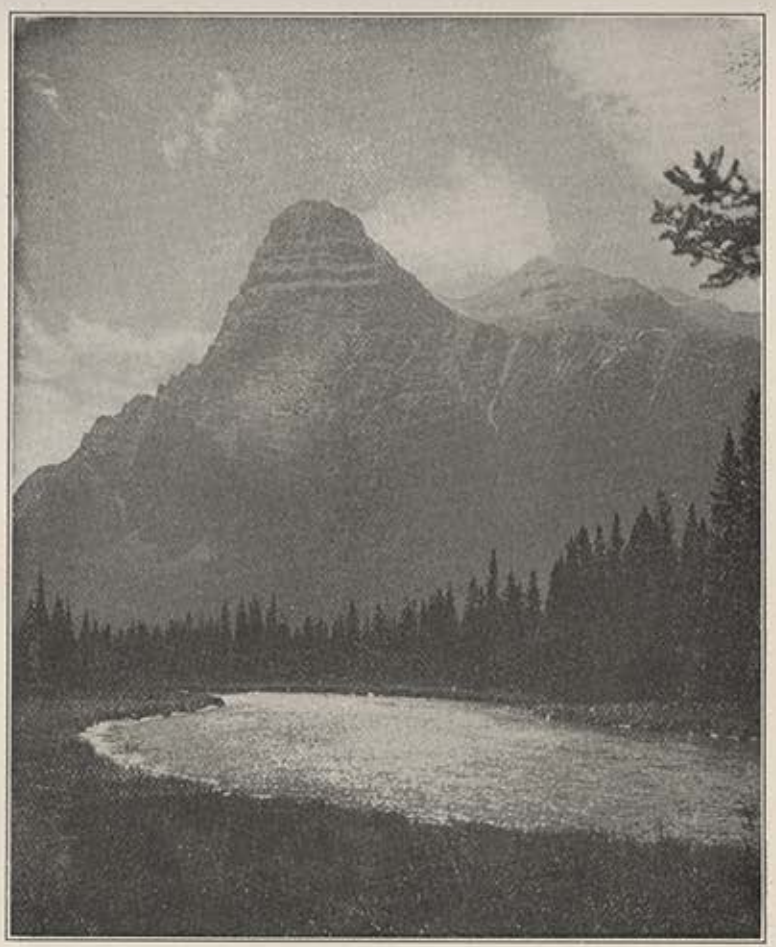

Fig. 7.—Pyramid Peak and Bear Creek, Forty Miles North of Laggan.

AMONG THE SOURCES OF THE SASKATCHEWAN AND ATHABASCA RIVERS.

MARY T. S. SCHÄFFER.

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AMONG THE SOURCES OF THE SASKATCHEWAN AND ATHABASCA RIVERS.

MARY T. S. SCHÄFFER.

The primary reason for writing this paper is, that it may bear its quota of usefulness to any who may be inclined to visit the section described. As to the location of the ground covered, from a glance at Dr. J. Norman Collie's map which accompanies his book —"Climbs and Explorations in the Canadian Rockies," it will be found to be bounded by latitudes 51′ 25″ to 52′ 25″, and longitudes 116′ to 118′. This is of course a rough outline, but it contains all the tributaries of those two great rivers of the north, which we visited. Our greatest trouble in the spring of 1907, was to obtain information which would be of even the smallest use in pointing out the way over such almost undescribed ground.[1]

Dr. Collie's book has summed up the work of himself and his friends, with that of previous workers in the same field, *i. e.*, the section lying between Laggan and Wilcox Pass; the Fortress Lake region and the Brazeau country belong to Dr. Coleman. As for the Yellow-head Pass, it is a matter of rather ancient history, having been described as far back as the days of Alexander Henry, an employee of the Northwest Fur Trading Co., who has left us an interesting diary, which covers the years between 1799 and 1814. The old history of the pass was of small practical use to us however, as it was the intervening valleys between this pass and the Kicking Horse Pass (that which the Canadian Pacific uses to-day), which we wished to explore.

[1] In spite of a general knowledge of the subject, we were unable to get at the material, and not until after our return to civilization, were we fortunate enough to obtain literature and maps which would have been so valuable to us in the far wilderness. One who goes hence should carry Dr. Collie's map. This is easy to obtain, being published with his "Climbs and Explorations"; Outram's map which accompanies his work—"In the Heart of the Canadian Rockies," may be of equal value; Dr. A. P. Coleman's articles published in the *Royal Geographical Journals*, are of great use; and James McEvoy's report on the Government Geological Survey of that section is a most interesting pamphlet to have. From these few sources is to be culled all the practical information that can be found on the country.

To know that the expedition was a momentous one to those involved in its success, one has but to read the warnings of those who have gone before. We may well call it the "Inhospitable Land." A well-known hunting-country, many have gone into its fastnesses, only to be driven out by starvation, and the added sorrow of lost, starved, or drowned horses. Dr. Collie but voices that which may be read between the lines of all those who have written their experiences in this country. He says: "Jean Habel's outfit, like so many others, ran short of provisions and the expedition had to be curtailed; and much good work of exploration, which might otherwise have been accomplished, was thereby prevented. Some day perhaps, it will be possible to obtain an outfit manned and equipped with sufficient transport and provisions to last out a trip of three or four months. At present nobody seems to have mastered the problem; and the prospect of running short of food on the journey remains the most serious obstacle to all projects of extended exploration among the mountains."

That we would be tempted to dally day by day, we well knew, that the game was becoming, year by year, more scarce, previous trips and the hard experience of others had warned us; and the food problem became a very simple matter in arithmetic. As we had hopes of reaching most of the tributaries of the two rivers within the latitudes and longitudes given previously we reckoned food and clothing for four months. The season of 1907 was an uncommonly late one, and it was not till June 20, that we were able to leave all civilization behind and start for the higher passes. The morning of the twentieth, was anything but a typical June day, and the first twenty miles of the Bow trail were not what one might choose for a pleasure jaunt. It was spitting hail and snow, which struck not only our faces but deep into our souls; for those who had not the spirit of the wilds surging in their hearts, had prognosticated all sorts of mishaps, and if one were looking for "signs," they were about us in profusion. Our caravan consisted of eleven horses, one running light, that in case of chafed back or accident, there would be an extra one to use. This will seem an extravagance to many, but it proved to be one of the best investments in the entire outfit, as the appearance of our animals showed on our return to civilization, not a horse being out of commission, and every one of them capable of working four months longer.

The Bow trail to the summit of the pass, is at the present time, rather a discouraging proposition, but there is one satisfaction, it is one of the poorest bits of trail that is to be experienced throughout the entire trip. It was of course at its very worst this late June day, for the mountains were still discharging their winter snows into the soaked and over-flowing valleys. Dr. Collie's map, compiled from the work done by himself, Wilcox, Coleman, Drewry and McArthur, Noyes and Thompson, was our constant companion in the saddle. It is necessarily far from perfect, distances here and there being too long or too short, but a very good friend to have at all times. Often when the trail was dim or obscured, or completely lost, have I thought of and admired the men, who with only an occasional suggestion that the Indian hunter had been before them, fought their way through the discouraging valleys, found a passage round impassable gorges, and eventually reached the higher peaks of the Rocky Range.

The upper Bow Lakes and Bow Pass were the first plunge into fine scenery. If one may go no further, this is a trip worth taking. At the summit, where the spruces remind one of a great natural park, a short detour to the left leads over easy slopes to the cliffs which overhang Peyto Lake, the waters of which are the outpourings of the Wapta neve. It is the first glimpse of the Saskatchewan country.

Here at our feet Bear Creek (on some maps Mistaya (Bear) but never locally so-called) has its rise, flows north, taps the beautiful lakes known as the Waterfowl, goes rippling, and gurgling, and dancing along in happy oblivion to the superb panorama on both shores—Howse Peak, the stately Pyramid, the frowning Bungalow, and lastly Murchison, losing its final identity in the turbid Saskatchewan at the base of that great, wandering, outspread, pile of crags—Mt. Wilson. The days on Bear Creek grew hotter and hotter. We hurried along as fast as our heavily loaded horses would permit, knowing that each hour was adding inches to that angry, impetuous river and anxious to reach the other side before we had to swim for it. At 4 p. m., on June 25, we had crossed Bear Creek at its mouth (no easy matter when the water is high, for the river-bed is covered with huge bowlders) and faced the first serious proposition—crossing the Saskatchewan River. An excellent ford across the North Fork may be found about one mile

west of Bear Creek, and we were in the nick of time, twenty-four hours later would have meant swimming.

With minds at rest, we camped that night on a high bluff overlooking the North Fork; behind us rose the high walls of Mt. Wilson, while Murchison, Sarbach, Pyramid, and the Freshfields died away in rosy, then purpling shadows; night came down, and we realized at last our utter isolation. The door was closed for many days to come to other companionship and the situation was saved from a sense of loneliness only by our minds being devoted absolutely to the destruction of mosquitoes, an occupation which lasted for several weeks. From Bear Creek to Wilcox Pass the scenery is a succession of beautiful pictures. About ten miles from the summit of the pass, the trail leaves the shingle-flats of the river and mounts a long and arduous hill, eventually reaching a point about 1000 feet above the valley, where the timber being scarce, the views of the receding and on-coming peaks are wonderfully fine. About three miles below "Camp Parker" (an easily recognized camp-ground at the junction of Nigel Creek and the North Fork), the now fast-diminishing river makes a deep plunge, forming what we have called "Panther Falls." Soon after passing the falls, Mt. Athabasca comes into sight on the left; being 11,900 feet high, and snow-clad, it is a joy even to eyes now so used to mountains. From "Camp Parker" to the main pass is about five miles, but a canyon beyond it being said to make that way impracticable, the trail to the true pass on the right, is a little hard to find. There is an old and much used camp among the spruces on the high meadows, called "Camp Expectation." Reaching this, the forest is skirted for a quarter of a mile, when a pebbly river-bed is reached; this is followed up for a short distance when a good trail to the pass is struck. This hidden trail is well worth a search, any other route is a hard grind for the horses.

The pass itself is long, heavy, ugly travelling; if the day be cloudy, it could not be more uninteresting, but being 7800 feet high, there is a fine view of Mt. Athabasca to the southwest, while to the north is seen the group of mountains climbed and named by Dr. Collie and his party.

The first drop on the north side of the pass, is a long sharp hill, where a well-marked trail leads to "Sheep Camp," a name well-known to hunters. By this camp runs a beautiful stream head-

ing from Wilcox Pass, which we afterward named "Tangle Creek." Here the trail disappears as though it had dropped into the earth. It may help some future traveller to know that if he will cross this creek at the camp, bear well to the left in the forest, he will soon come upon a very good trail, which quickly leads to the Su Wapta in the valley below. Little Tangle Creek added quite a volume to the main river (an important branch of the Athabasca), and with its wide shingle-flats and guardian mountains on both sides, bore a strong resemblance to the Saskatchewan tributaries.

Unlike the Saskatchewan region, however, horse-feed here is limited and camp-grounds consequently scarce. The first possible stopping-place is at least two miles below the main Su Wapta canyon, and on the left side of the river. Even that is a very poor place, being but a small slough, with scarce feed enough for a dozen horses for one night. The next feeding place is found in the quick-sand belt, five to seven miles further down the river. This does not sound attractive for the horses, but unless it be early spring, there is little danger. This quick-sand is not a pleasing problem; it extends down the river at least three miles, and there being no way to go round, it must be traversed. Beyond it, and just north of the creek marked "Jonas" on the map, a large rock-slide of recent origin, gave us our next bit of study. It was soon navigated however by plowing through the muskeg on the west side of the river for at least four hundred yards, when we struck dry ground and a bit of a trail, and "going" was easy again. Beyond the rock-slide, Jonas Creek emptied its clear waters into the muddy Su Wapta, while a little further on, and flowing in a parallel direction, Pobokton Creek appeared from amidst the thick, green forest. Dr. Coleman, who named both creeks, told us later, that the names had been transposed on Collie's map, but for fear of still further misunderstanding—we let them alone. Beyond Pobokton (Owl) Creek, a long, rather low, rocky range marks the course of the main river for miles. For a day and a half we followed it in all its tiresomeness. Reaching the junction of the Su Wapta and the Athabasca, and seeing that it still continued in more or less broken form on down the Athabasca valley, we dubbed it "the Endless Chain."

The Athabasca at this junction, gave us no such impression of might and strength as the Saskatchewan at an equal distance from

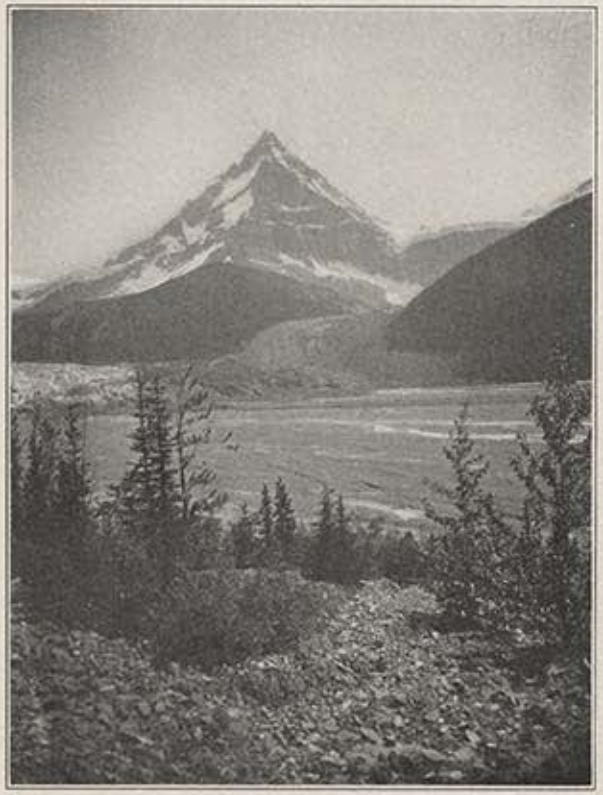
its source, the great ice-fields of the Columbia and surrounding peaks evidently contributed much more largely to the southern river.

The Athabasca, at its source, is divided into three streams, and till they are reached at their junction, almost all scenic beauty is at a standstill. Not so the mosquitoes, deer-flies, bull-dogs, and caribou-flies; they were there by the millions to torment man and beast; but not even they could deter us from a desire to see Fortress Lake, discovered and named by Dr. Coleman in 1893, visited by Wilcox in 1896, and Habel in 1901.

In my diary I find this entry, "July 10, Indian Camp (our camps were all named to avoid confusion). The mosquitoes have shrieked and buzzed all night about our heads. If the number increases in direct ratio to the number of miles we go, at Fortress Lake we will be breathing and eating the pests." The words proved later to be almost a prophecy, though it was a matter of flies, not mosquitoes. While visiting the South or Columbia branch of the Athabasca, we were surrounded and overwhelmed, one evening at supper, by thousands of tiny flies, which though they did not bite, clung in clouds about us, drowned in our tea, became hopelessly entangled in the butter, died by hundreds in the apple-sauce, flew into ears, eyes, and nostrils, till we were distracted.

Having crossed the southeast branch of the Athabasca, we continued along the southwest branch, which Coleman has named the Chaba (beaver). Here we found a paradise for the horses, and made camp under the shadow of a noble crag, which proved later to be Fortress Mountain, and for which the lake was named. The lake being still an unknown quantity, the following day we made the ascent of a mountain (Mt. Quincy) opposite the Fortress and after a long, hot, weary scramble, Fortress Lake burst upon our sight, lying like an exquisite blue-green ribbon among the spruce-grown valleys below. It is about nine miles long, with an imposing mountain heavily covered with snow, rising at the far end. Habel has called it Mt. Blanc, while Wilcox seems to think it the long-lost Hooker.

Heavy thunder-showers prevented any photography worth mentioning, and we returned to camp to move our belongings to the shores of the lake. Beautiful as the lake in its exquisite setting is, it is no place for a permanent camp. The eastern end of the lake is a marsh, while the north and south shores are impenetrable



Mt. Columbia from the North.

Camp at Nashan-esen Lake at Thompson Pass.

owing to the dense forests and undergrowth. A raft was the only practical solution for reaching the western terminus and main outlet of the lake, and that was out of the question for us, as we had nothing with us but our valuable lash-ropes. Consequently we contented ourselves with a trip on our horses to the end of the Chaba valley, which proved to be about five miles long. Two miles south of the lake a stream joins the Chaba from the southeast and seems longer than the Chaba. The end of the Chaba valley is blocked by two fine glacier-tongues heavily covered with debris; a huge avalanche, 30 or 40 feet thick, choked the narrow gorge one half mile from the extreme end, on our visit in 1907 (Habel mentions the same in 1901) while beautiful water-falls on our right fell hundreds of feet from the precipices looming far above our heads.

Beautiful as Fortress Lake and her surrounding crags were, we were glad to say "good-bye" after thirty-six hours on her oozing inhospitable shores and turn our faces toward the more southeasterly branch of the Athabasca. To this stream we were particularly tempted by having seen from a distance, an uncommonly fine pyramidal, snow-capped peak, which we later decided could be no other than Collie's Mt. Columbia. Habel, who is the only other white person to have entered this valley so far as is known, records it in a short paper in *Appalachia* as "Gamma," and has reproduced with it a most striking picture. To the northeast of Columbia, a long spur juts out from that mountain, which we called "Edward the Seventh." The aspect of this valley is totally different from that of the Chaba. It is about 25 miles in length; the stream at the junction of the two rivers seems to be about one half the size it is twelve miles nearer its source (bespeaking an underground passage), while muskegs and bottomless mountain streams make the travelling wearisome for at least fifteen miles. The last day's ride was one of uncommon impressiveness, and I quote from my diary. "August 1. To-day the hill-sides on both right and left, were wooded to the base with rich, deep-green spruces, mountain-torrents like snowy threads peeped from amidst the foliage and the tumbling waters sent forth a music not to be surpassed. The thud of the horses' feet, the rushing of the glaciated river, and all else was silent. Columbia, which Collie reckons as 12,000 feet, loomed in pyramidal majesty at the end of the valley, while high surrounding peaks came and went as we crept along among the lower hills.

Alberta, Wooley, Stutfield, Diadem, and other mountains figured in our names for the unknown summits, but our point of observation was far too low, to be at all certain of any of them. Caribou tracks grew more and more numerous; here and there teepee-poles on the open hill-sides bespoke the some-time presence of the Indian hunter. With no timber-work to impede our progress, we rapidly neared the base of Mt. Columbia. Our course lay across the wide shingle-flats, which then, at low water, was a garden of the pink Epilobium (*Chamænerion latifolium*) and here and there silvery cascades fell hundreds of feet down sheer cliffs."

About two miles north of Mt. Columbia, a much longer stream comes in from the west; this we explored the next day, but as usual, the clouds came down and obliterated everything of interest. Apparently there is a high mountain at the far end, and a glacier flowing from it, seems worthy of study. Having in our ignorance, dragged our horses to the base of Mt. Columbia, we quickly saw we must drag them away again on account of feed, so retired to two small islands four miles down the river, where a limited amount of slough-grass was found on the river's left. Throughout the entire Athabasca region this problem of feed was almost as serious as the rivers themselves. After waiting three days, we never got any particularly fine pictures of that wonderful mountain, being at all times either surrounded by clouds, or else steeped in flat sunshine.

From the Columbia Branch, we now traced our way back to the main Athabasca, and from there to the Su Wapta, where we went in search of the Su Wapta Gorge. We found it within a mile of the mouth, and though the whole country is a country of gorges, this one is uncommonly fine. The walls are probably 150 feet high, the water makes a plunge of 50 feet at the upper end, then rushes seething and boiling through a deep elbow-shaped cut. Some one has hewn and thrown three trees across the narrowest part of the gorge (perhaps 20 feet wide), and cut on a near-by tree the facetious notice, " No toll charged on this bridge." We had intended our next stopping-place to be Diadem Creek, where we hoped to climb and locate the peaks named by Collie's party in that section. This was however impossible as there was not a sign of horse-feed, and we were compelled to move on up the river for two miles where we went into camp for a couple of days. Here we ascended a creek

to the fine glacier at its source, climbed a low mountain on the creek's left (about 9000 feet), and were undoubtedly in the midst of Wooley, Stutfield and Diadem, but which was which, it was hard to say with the limited description given by their sponsors. On August 16, we climbed Peak Wilcox (10,050 feet), and should have had an interesting view of the country we had just come from, and others to which we were bound—but for the usual clouds.

On August 17, we were camped at 7000 feet, just below Wilcox Pass. The morning opened with a regular, old-fashioned snow-storm, and the arrival at our tent-door of a total stranger before any one was awake. It was a queer sensation, looking out from one's sleeping-bag and seeing a man when there was no cause to think that such an object save our own guides were within a hundred miles of us. It proved to be Dr. Coleman's party, Dr. Coleman who had threaded the by-ways of so much of this country through which we had just been, and of whom we had spoken so often while in the mazes of the Athabasca sources.

It proved a pleasant meeting in spite of driving snows, and we parted—they for the Yellow-head Pass and we for the West Branch and the Brazeau country. "The West-Branch-of-the-North-Fork-of-the-Saskatchewan!" The most beautiful valley of all those we visited, and to go by such a name! May it some day receive its due; certain it is, it has not had it yet. It is essentially a valley of tumbling cascades and deep gorges, of muskegs and sloughs at its mouth, and shingle-flats at its source, with few good camp-grounds except *on* the pass. It runs in a straight line for about fifteen miles, when Mts. Alexandra, Gable and Lyell, with their snowy glaciers block the way. Here at right angles, another stream comes in direct from Thompson Pass and the Columbia ice-fields, about fifteen miles distant. To avoid the hard travelling which following the river involves, those who may follow in the future will find a hunter's shack about five miles east of the base of Gable Peak, on the river's left. Fifty yards to the east of it, they will strike into the mountain and there come upon a fairly good trail winding over the shoulder of the hill. No packs had ever been to the summit of the Thompson Pass before, and it took some careful work to get the loaded animals up and around the rock ridges which balked us every few yards. What a camp that was by the calm, deep-green lake, which lies at the foot of Outram's Watchman's Peak! Not

even the sign of the indefatigable Indian hunter was visible, only the little people of the wilderness, whose trails were everywhere. We drank from the clear, cold waters, and named it "Nashan-esen" —Stoney for "Wolverine-go-quick," our friend the hunter—Simpson.

We found the task of taking the horses to the summit of Thompson Pass a much easier one than we had first hoped. It is very steep in places, but the rock ridges, running transversely to the valley, made good shelves for footing. A good camp ground will be found a few hundred feet below the 6800 foot summit, on the lake shore. A low spur of Mt. Bryce, altitude about 9000 feet, gave us that which we had come so far to see, a view of the great Columbia ice-fields. Stretching for thirty miles to the north, the sight was one never to be forgotten! . So cold, so still, so silent and haughty in their supreme, icy beauty, they well repaid for all the hardships of reaching them. Outram says they contain at least 200 square miles, and it can well be believed, from our point of vantage there seemed no limit to the billows and billows of ice. It was a grand marshaling of the monarchs. We stood in the heart of the highest which the Rocky range has to give to those who love the hills; and at last I was willing to admit, that in spite of the drudgery and fatigue, there is a fascination in reaching the "top." The nipping winds however, stiffened our enthusiasm for even that wonderful sight; so with a brisk run down the sliding scree, a plunge through the low scrub, a few tumbles over the rocks, we were back at Nashan-esen Camp, and a delicious supper of bacon and beans.

As we emerged from the wonderful valley, in a downpour of rain, we christened it "Nashan-esen," hoping that "West-Branch-of-the-North-Fork" might some day be forgotten.

September 5, saw us heading for Nigel Pass and the Brazeau country. The trail lies on the river's left, and at the summit, it will be found to wind among the rocks on the south side of the pass. When once found, the way proved perfectly easy going, having no doubt been a very old Indian trail.

On the far side of the pass, one branch of the Brazeau has its rise; this branch we followed for about 30 miles to the Brazeau Lake, keeping on the river's left for the first ten miles, when what there is of trail, crosses to the right side, and eventually surmounts a long, hilly shoulder and drops down to the main river.

Brazeau Lake is a beautiful, aquamarine sheet of water about six miles long, whose low surrounding mountains, on that sunny morning of our introduction to it, were exquisitely reflected in its mirrored surface. We found a well-marked trail on its eastern shore, and every indication that it had long been a favorite hunting-ground of the Indians. Pushing on by an old and ideal camp-ground at the lower end of the lake, we camped that night at its northern extremity. Beyond the lake the valley extends for fully twelve miles. At its extreme limit rises a fine peak, which Coleman has called Mt. Brazeau, and though unclimbed, he reckons it at 11,000 feet or over. Tempted by an old but very good Indian trail, we followed it the next day, to the very limit of horse climbing, or close on to 9000 feet, and reached as dreary an alpine view as I ever saw. There was but one event to redeem and justify the expedition. The snow lay deep, even below tree-line, the icy winds whistled through the spruces, and shrieked past the bare rock ridges, and the low-hanging clouds obscured the higher and distant peaks. At last even the dying alpine flowers were left behind, and we crossed a rocky ridge to meet a band of mountain sheep. Surprised at our sudden coming, in the twinkling of an eye, they had scaled impossible cliffs covered with ice, and were gazing down upon us from 1000 feet above. The brave old ram his head accentuated with a pair of magnificent horns, never flinched from his post, or removed his eye from the enemy, till in our descent, the lower jutting rocks hid us from view. Returning up the Brazeau River, we took a side trip to Jonas Pass, the stream from which flows into the Brazeau about five miles from Nigel Pass. This pass was tried by a white man in 1893, Dr. Coleman, when finding his way to the Yellowhead Pass; and excepting one hunter, I have heard of no one using it since. In many ways it is an improvement on the Wilcox Pass by which to reach the Athabasca, avoiding much that is disagreeable on the Su Wapta. To us at this late season of the year, it had no "tourist" charms. The summit of the pass was burdened with two, three, and even four feet of snow, which with the hard work on the horses, the brilliant glare on unprotected eyes from the snow, and the cutting, driving wind lashing our faces, seemed endless. A fine, solitary black bear, out for any belated berries, he might find beneath the snow, was the

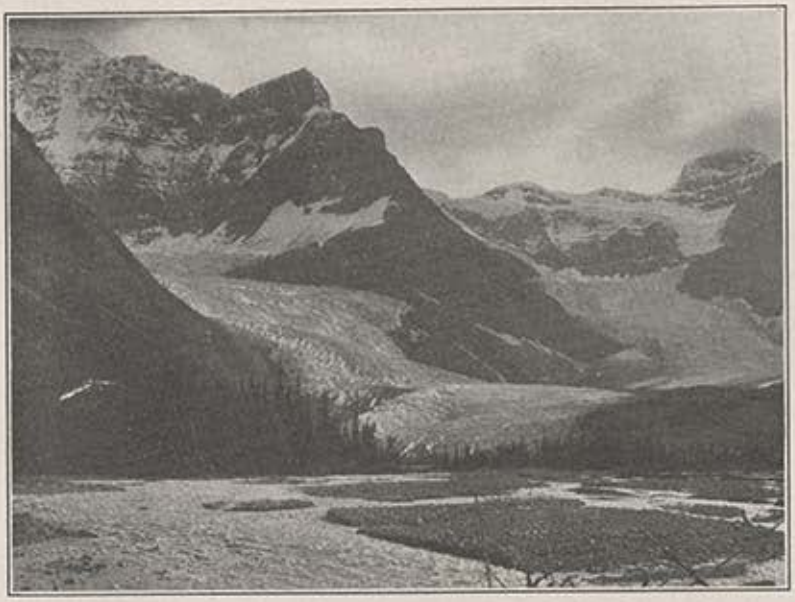
only bit of life to greet us on the great white silent stretch of loneliness.

September 21 saw us anxiously scanning the clouds and a rift in the hills to the south of us, from our camp on the Brazeau. We were to try still another new pass, the Cataract, and this also almost unknown except to Coleman. Being but 200 feet lower than "Jonas," or 7550 feet high, we had little to expect in the way of an open trail. It proved to be quite all that we could ask to get our horses through, and was even more tedious than "Jonas." The Indian trail through the forest is well marked, and had there been no snow, we might have found such a trail as that which goes over Nigel Pass; as it was, it was one long hard grind through fine, fluffy snow, which allowed the horses to sink almost to the rocks beneath, plunge forward, and sink again.

The south side of the pass is excessively tedious, as much of the way is avalanche-swept, and the apology for a trail is constantly blocked by fallen timbers. From the summit of the Pass to Pinto Lake is about fifteen miles. Here, owing to a pair of snow-blind eyes, we were forced to remain over a day; and as provisions were getting low, the guides reinforced by three of the strongest horses, pack-saddles, and ropes, crossed Pinto Pass to the junction of the North Fork and Nashan-esen Rivers, and returned that night with the food we had cached at that point. It was only a matter of thirty miles, but it was over a pass which even Dr. Coleman gave up attempting with horses after investigating it for that purpose.

We had traversed it the year before from the west to the east, but that was a different undertaking from this expedition, when the men were compelled to cut steps in the ice near the summit to enable the animals to get any foot-hold at all. Pinto Lake has long been a favorite fishing-ground for the Stoney Indians; they had just made a visitation to those waters, and as Indians always do, had cleaned out every fish that would rise to bait.

From Pinto Lake to the Kootenai Plains the trail follows Cataract Creek. It is a distance of about twenty-five miles to its junction with the main river, more or less uninteresting, and fire-swept from end to end. In the late fall the Saskatchewan is easy enough to ford where it divides into several channels near the base of the Sentinel Mountain. On the golden Kootenai Plains we rested and dallied among the Indians for a few days, then



Gable and Alexandra Glaciers in Nashan-ésen Valley.

"Mummery" on Baker Pass.

hurried to the junction of Bear Creek and the Saskatchewan, crossed that river and ascended the North Fork in search of a valley, which Outram mentions on his map, "The-Valley-of-the-Lakes." The entrance to this valley is quite nine miles from the mouth of the North Fork. At low water, a ford may be easily made opposite the rift in the hills, but at high water, can only be reached by crossing below on the main stream and following the west shore of the river. The trip though short, was an arduous one, and almost devoid of real interest. We found a very ancient Indian trail, which needed much circumnavigating and cutting, to get even our now depleted packs through; the growth was very heavy and the way consequently dark and gloomy. By a brawling, noisy little river, we made the only camp where a sign of feed seemed possible for the tired horses, and that in the midst of fallen timbers on the avalanche-swept hill-sides. Outram describes this valley as he saw it from the summit of Mt. Lyell, 11,500 feet below him; we saw it at 8000 feet, where we climbed the following day, the sun beating down upon us, and the surrounding clouds so low that Lyell and everything else interesting was utterly obscured. The lovely lakes were only sloughs after all and the chief joy of the trip proved to be that we had been the first travellers to break the spell of silence in that lonely cleft of the hills. It had been many years since an Indian had been there, and the only other sign of life, was the blow of the axe from a solitary white hunter who had passed in the dead of winter. It was now October 5, and Howse and Baker Passes, our return route, quite unknown. Up the Middle Fork and to the Howse Pass, was like reading ancient history. One hundred and fifty years ago, the Indians from the Kootenai country took this portion of the trail on their journey to the Saskatchewan Plains (hence the name Kootenai Plains), to trade with Kline of Jasper House. As far as Howse Pass, it was delightful trailing; being but 4800 feet, we were on and over almost before we knew, and soon tumbling down beside the merry, chattering Blaeberry River. The instant Howse Pass is crossed, the character of the vegetation changes, and the trail becomes impeded with heavy fallen timber and an almost tropical undergrowth. Government surveyors had preceded us in the fall of 1907, and though the way was not a bed of roses, miles and miles of fatiguing work had been saved our men as far as the "Hunter's Cabin."

On Dr. Collie's map, one has but to follow a plain red line, which turns to the left of the "Cabin"; and the Baker Pass seems the easiest thing imaginable. In reality, the Blaeberry is followed for two miles further after passing the second cabin (we never saw the first one), when the trail turns sharply to the left and winds up a hill-side. This emerges shortly on a very bowldery river-bed, which is to be crossed at the traveller's discretion, when Baker Pass with its trials and tribulations begins. Again I quote from my diary. "Quite ignorant of distances by this time, our horses having had but little feed for the last three days, and having already come ten miles since morning, we with only our saddle-animals pushed ahead with the injunction to stop for camp at the first sign of grass." It was quite noon, and we hurried along. The trail lay over a steep moss-covered slope, so steep there was no thought of riding; so steep, that place after place the horses would spring one and two feet to reach a bench above; so steep and continuous, that they were forced to cling to the hill-sides while resting.

Pack and saddle-horses were all soon in a dripping perspiration. Occasionally a call would come from behind, "Is there any end to it?" There seemed none. The way was clear and well blazed, we must be on the trail and on we climbed—climbed till we reached timber-line at five o'clock. Not a mouthful of feed had we passed since leaving "Trapper's Cabin"—blueberry-bushes and moss, no more. Were we even on Baker Pass, and if so, why had we climbed to this high point? *We* could have camped anywhere, it was our starving horses to whom our thoughts turned.

W., who had pulled us out of so many straits, went off to investigate; the time seemed interminable as we watched the slowly descending sun, now almost at the horizon. Mt. Mummery looked down upon us in icy indifference from across the valley, we stood clinging to the half frozen hill-side, while the weary, hungry horses, with drooping heads, tried to retain a foothold on the slippery, sliding mud. No one had had a mouthful of food since breakfast (we had come fully twenty miles), darkness would soon be upon us, we were 7200 feet above sea-level, and under the circumstances, no one could honestly say he felt cheerful. Then W. returned with the good news that though he was not positive we were on the right track, he saw a slough in a valley below, with indications of feed, and he thought we might reach it before dark. We forgot hunger,

mud, cold, everything but that grass below; and as though the horses had understood, with us, plunged down a long, mossy gully, in a very few minutes dropping 1000 feet to a tiny stream which was flowing exactly as we wished it to flow. The sight of a horse's imprint cheered us; off came the packs, "no hobbles to-night, there is grass in plenty, and wherever we be, there are two days' rest for our faithful friends." The next day disclosed the fact that we had really struck the Baker Pass, were right on it in fact; but after studying the map and the hours of travel the day before we found the map made the distance about ten miles, while we had travelled twenty. Under the circumstances it seemed rather excusable, that for once we had felt a sensation of being lost. Climbing a shoulder of Mt. Habel the next day, we soon had our bearings, looked down into the "Gap" and upon an exquisite little lake poised high on a shoulder nearest the Yoho; to the north, Mummery and Forbes. With binoculars we could see the cairns on Collie and the Vice-President; and into the Beaver-tail Valley—our way home.

SCIENTIFIC SECTION.

FLORA OF THE SASKATCHEWAN AND ATHABASCA RIVER TRIBUTARIES.

By Mary T. S. Schaffer.

Another sketch appears in this magazine referring directly to the localities of whose florae I have been asked to write, so there is no need to duplicate a description of the ground covered.

As our stay was to be a long one, it was with dubious feelings that we asked permission to include among the necessities a plant-press and a limited supply of paper. Having collected plants from Banff to Glacier during a number of years, there were days on the earlier part of the journey when we would have been glad to get rid of the cumbersome, troublesome thing, and leave it hanging on some tree till we should return in the fall. But there came a day when a trained botanist went over the result of our perseverence, and we felt repaid for the annoyance and labor involved in gathering the unfamiliar blossoms by the wayside.

Mr. Stewardson Brown, of Philadelphia, has had them all thoroughly studied, and I herewith give a few notes, the result of his work upon them.

As far as the Wilcox Pass we found nothing particularly striking, until reaching a point at about 6000 feet we found the *Pinus flexilus,* its blue-green foliage betraying it quickly among the browner-green of the other trees. The cones, at that time a deep purple, vary from three to five inches in length. From there on we met many strangers (to us) of the plant world. The *Picea Canadensis,* not seen further south, was first noticed on the north shores of the Saskatchewan.

m 70 5

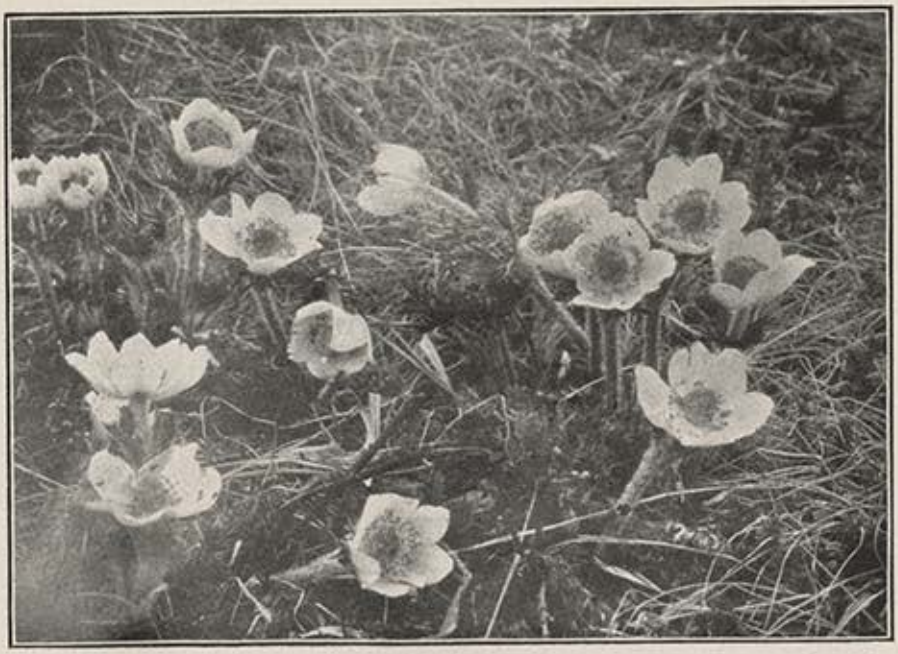
The *Erigeron acris* we found in August a few hundred feet below the *Pinus flexilus,* and, in the beginning of July, at 8500 feet, the *Ranunculus pygmaeus,* the tiniest butter-cup imaginable, struggling bravely to bloom in the icy winds of Wilcox Pass, and covering the ground like a golden moss wherever the winter snows had receded. Here, also, in full bloom, but or more exposed and barren sections of the pass, was the *Aragallus inflatus.* This was an especially interesting find as I had never seen anything more than the huge, inflated seed-pods before. The flower is a deep sky-blue, and, growing only upon higher elevations, not often seen. We gathered the beautiful crimsoning seed-vessels at the same place, the latter part of August.

From the north fork of the Saskatchewan to the headwaters of the Athabasca the *Primula mistassinica* and the *Primula borealis* grew by the river banks, frequently in beds together; they were as often found apart.

In the Su Wapta flats was growing the *Pilosella Richardsonii,* as also the *Arabis lyrata occidentalis.* The former plant, varying in general characteristics, but withal the same, made our entire journey to Fortress Lake bright, its clusters of white blossoms garnishing the sandy river-bars.

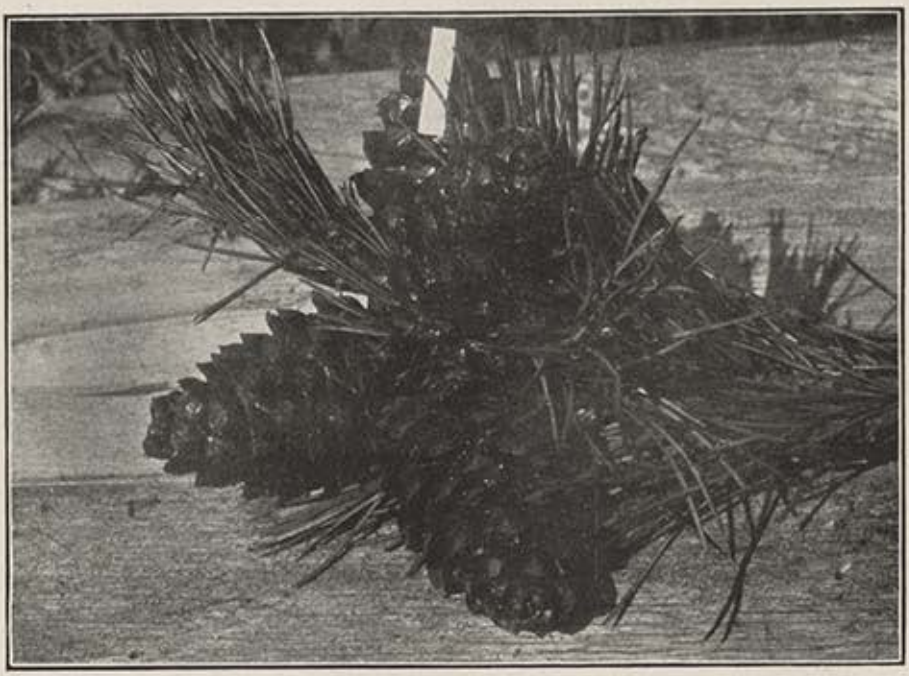
On the Wilcox Pass grew the *Viola cognata,* and in the Fortress Lake region, at about 7000 feet, the *Viola Langsdorfii.* This violet is an especially beautiful, rich, luscious-looking flower, with strong, rank foliage.

Down in the swamps of the Su Wapta we found the *Utricularia vulgaris,* and though known generally throughout Canada, I have never come across it in the mountains further south. At the same time of year, and in the same section, but at 7000 feet, we found the purple-crimson blooms of the *Telesonix heucheriformis.* Wedged deep in the cracks of the rocks, it was impossible to get any of the specimens entire. One and



Mary T. S. Schaffer, Photo

PULSATILLA OCCIDENTALIS



Mary T. S. Schaffer, Photo

PINUS FLEXILUS

two hundred feet above this point we found the strawberry (*Fragaris bracteata*) : great luscious berries three-quarters to one inch long. Sweeter than many a cultivated variety, they were welcome company at a height where there was no water.

On September 9th, we climbed a bare, rocky point to look for Brazeau Lake. There was little of the floral life left, though fungi of many varieties were very numerous, even to tree-line, and we were surprised to come across the little *Erigeron lanatus* at 9000 feet. The plant was a new one to me, though Professor Macoun mentions finding it at high points further south. The rays are a deep rose-violet, and the rest of the plant covered with long white hairs. As it lay blooming in the scree close to the summit of the mountain, it had the appearance of a purple flower nestling in a bed of cotton.

By the latter part of August all the river banks were a continuous strawberry bed, a welcome addition to our limited larder, but we never saw a bush of the blueberry (*Vaccinium ovaliform*) which grows so profusely in the Selkirks. Occasionally we came across the *Vaccinium erythrococcum,* whose tiny red berries made very tiresome picking, but were very good and toothsome when once gathered.

We found very many plants familiar to us as growing near the railroad, but with limited space I have only jotted down the strangers. It will be seen by this list that they are largely the plants best known as having their habitation in the more northern mountains of the Pacific slope.

We had stolen a march into the meeting grounds of two distinct floral sections, an interesting ground for a botanist who has time in the future to go so far from the beaten way.

MISCELLANEOUS SECTION.

UNTRODDEN WAYS.

By Mary T. S. Schaffer.

In the summer of 1907, on June 20th, two women and two guides left the little station of Laggan, Alberta, and started for the vast wilderness to the north. It was cold and raw, snow flew in our not over-jubilant faces, the way was one of grind over fallen timbers and through the most discouraging muskegs. For our trail lay up the Bow Valley, across the summit of the same name, down Mistaya Creek to its junction with the Saskatchewan River, and from thence on by the various branches of the Saskatchewan and Athabasca Rivers.

Not as the crow flies, but as the trail winds, we reached in our wanderings a point about 200 miles from Laggan, not far from the junction of the Whirlpool and Athabasca Rivers. In this section there are four distinct streams: the Chaba, which flows up from the south and joins the West Branch of the Athabasca about twelve miles from its own source; a branch which flows from the south-east and joins the Chaba about three miles from the latter's source; the West Branch mentioned above, and the Sun Wapta, which joins the main stream several miles below. About half way up the Chaba, and to the west of it, lies beautiful Fortress Lake, discovered in 1893 by Dr. A. P. Coleman. It is a wild and strikingly picturesque valley, though probably not more so than many similarly situated on the Saskatchewan River. Yet the West Branch appealed to us more; there was a sense of loneliness, of freedom from all touch of human life, a purity, a bloom, which the white man's hand so quickly brushes aside. I say "white," for the red man defiles it no more than does

the passing caribou or the wandering bear. His standing teepee-poles but give the touch the artist loves, while the centuries-old hunting trails are filled with soundless stories which interested eyes may easily read as they follow in the wake of the feet that have gone by and will never return.

As far as I can learn, only one white man has ever penetrated to the end of the West Branch, and this was Jean Habel, a German explorer, who visited it in the summer of 1901. He did not then recognize the superb pyramid of faultless outline which stands guard at the extreme southern limit of the valley as Mt. Columbia, and called it "Gamma." He afterwards published a short article in "Appalachia" with a fine reproduction of Mt. Columbia, but before he could do more, or his work be better known, the pen was laid aside forever; and it was with a feeling of sincere sadness that we passed his long-deserted camps, and realized so vividly the feelings which must have thrilled him as he saw the rich scenic treasures the mountains were unfolding for the first time to human eyes.

Next to being asked if we were not "afraid" in that lonely wilderness, the most common question is: "Did you go where no person had ever been before?" An Indian after all is a "person," and to find a spot where an Indian has not been in that great hunting ground, which has doubtless been hunted over from time immemorial by the plains tribes, would seem an absolute impossibility. The caribou, goat and sheep yet wander in these lonely fastnesses, and a few Indians still come to the haunts of their forefathers; but in the further valleys the teepee-poles are fallen and decayed, and thus the story of the passing of the red man is simply and sadly told. So to that question I can only reply: We found one section, and but one, where it seemed as if not even an Indian's foot had trodden. This was on the north shore of the Athabasca River after the four

Mary T. S. Schaffer, Photo

FORTRESS LAKE

Mary T. S. Schaffer, Photo

MOUNT COLUMBIA

streams had united. The original explorer had chosen the south and more "muskeggy" ground, where we ourselves were forced to travel to avoid the arduous labor of chopping a trail. This was the only section of the eight or nine hundred miles we travelled where there was a doubt that Indians had gone; at least, it had never been a highway.

From the Athabasca we turned our attention to the sources of the Saskatchewan and Brazeau Rivers, to the "Valley of the Lakes," a branch of the North Fork of the former stream, and to the West Branch, a tributary of the Saskatchewan flowing from the Lyell group. This valley alone is worth a trip, an article to itself, and a more ready pen. It is a valley of gorges and glaciers, magnificent peaks and tumbling waterfalls, and holds a charming lake which we have named "Nashanesen."* The climax is reached at the Thompson Pass, where the traveller who has stuck to it through pretty rough "going" is at last rewarded by his first glimpse of Mt. Bryce, and from a shoulder of the mountain the vast ice-fields of Mt. Columbia.

From the West Branch we crossed by Nigel Pass to the Brazeau country lying to the north-east of the Wilcox Pass. Roughly speaking, Brazeau Lake lies in latitude 53° and longitude 117°. It is about six miles long, is wooded round its shores, and at its head stands a fine peak—Mt. Brazeau. Low mountains hem it in on all sides, and, on a calm morning, before the sun has risen or the wind has cast a ripple on its blue-green surface, the sight is one of exquisite beauty.

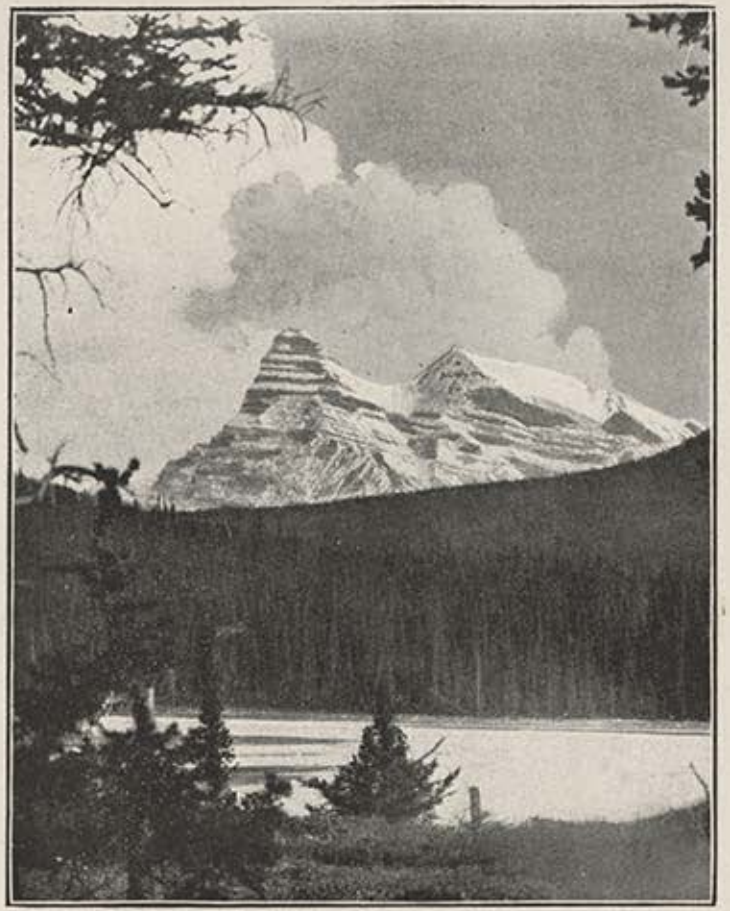
We no sooner reached the southern shore of the lake than a whole volume was opened for us to read. In a perfect grove among the spruces stood comparatively fresh teepee-poles, while tossed here and there, in every stage of decay, were those which had served their pur-

*Names given in Canada are subject to approval by the Geographical Board.—Editor.

pose many, many years before. An old trail was beaten deep within the forest, and from this path sprang ancient trees which held their proud boughs to the blue sky above, their lower bark scarred and gashed by hands long laid beneath the sod.

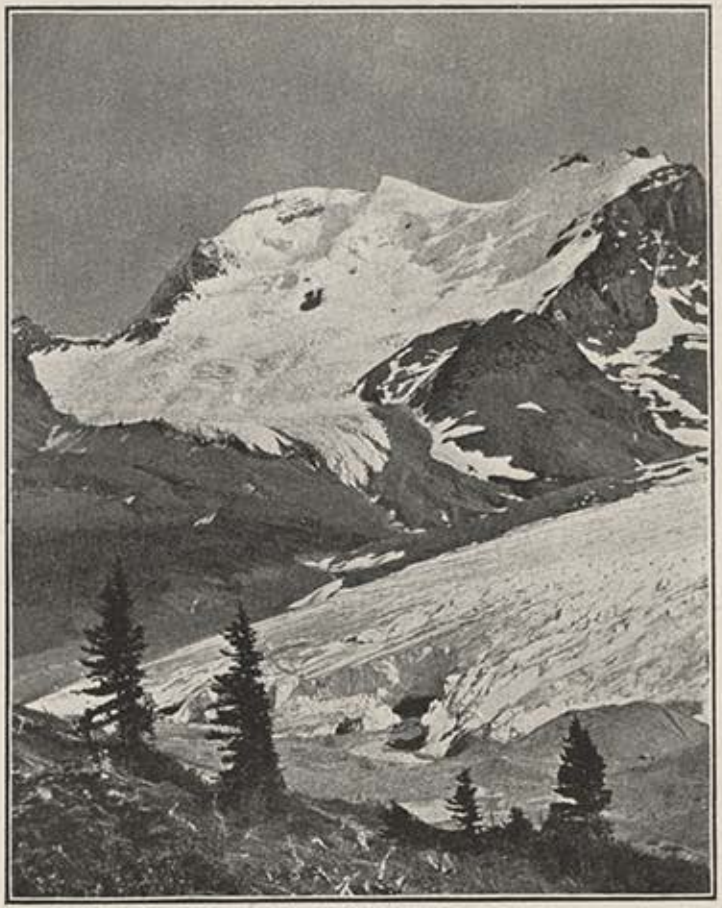
That it was and yet is a magnificent sheep country, there is little doubt. Its long distance from the now small band of Stony Indians at Morley and the nearly exhausted game country intervening, is probably a sufficient reason for the greater abundance of animal life which we saw there. We had followed a most marvellous Indian trail over the worst bed of boulders I ever met for horses to travel, had climbed on and on, lured by the old trail, until well toward 9,000 feet, when we suddenly surprised a band of sheep. They had probably never seen a human being before. On the defensive at once, they were off like a flash before our astonished gaze, along a bare rock-face and up an almost perpendicular wall covered with ice that the most fearless Swiss guide would not have dared attempt, and over which they bounded as though it were but a meadow of upland grass. Reaching the high and inaccessible crags, they paused, and for a moment gazed upon us far below; then a magnificent ram appeared to take the lead. The others disappeared, but the massive head of the leader, with its great horns, stood motionless against the grey sky, his attitude alert, his body immovable. Only, as we moved back and down the valley, we could discern that he turned to keep us in view. Such a picture! The dreary wastes of naked rock, the cold glistening glaciers all about us, the early snows in the unexposed niches, the dying alpine flowers at our feet, then, high above, clinging to the superb crags outlined against an angry sky, stood that emblem of a noble and fast-disappearing creature—the Rocky Mountain sheep.

From the Brazeau country we made our way back toward Nigel Pass, crossed Cataract Pass and descended



Mary T. S. Schaffer, Photo

PYRAMID PEAK
From Junction of North Fork and Main Saskatchewan



Mary T. S. Schaffer, Photo

MOUNT ATHABASCA
From Wilcox Pass

Cataract Creek to the Kootenai Plains. Here we rested and revelled in those golden valleys, visited the Indians, and found life a very pleasant matter in that peaceful sunshine after the snows and storms among the more northern valleys.

Yet even here the late September days were stealing. They were coming with the yellowing poplars, and with the laggard dawn. We knew the winter's snows must soon sweep across the higher passes, but begged a few days' respite to visit one spot which beckoned us with its beguiling name. This was the "Valley of the Lakes." James Outram speaks of seeing it from the summit of Mt. Lyell, and says in his book (*In the Heart of the Canadian Rockies*): "It appeared as a deep enshadowed trough, jewelled with a host of little lakes." The description fascinated us, appealed to our imagination, and we were to have the pleasure of stealing the first secrets of a primeval wilderness. From the camp at the junction of the North Fork and the main Saskatchewan River, we travelled up the east bank of the North Fork for about 13 miles; here, being low water, we easily found a crossing, and followed the west shore for a mile more, when an old Indian trail led directly to the unknown valley. As far as the red man is concerned, it is many years since his moccasined foot has trodden that moss-covered way. The trail remains beaten and worn, but overgrown and impeded with huge fallen trees, and only the blaze of a white man's axe seven or eight feet above the ground showed that a hunter had gone that way in the dead of winter to test his fortune with traps and rifle.

No sooner had we left the river than we plunged into a thick growth of spruce, climbing constantly for two hours. Reaching comparatively level ground, we plodded on amidst closely grown and exasperating pines, so thick and so nearly impregnable that even our now depleted packs could not be forced through until the

axe rang and woke the silence which seemed to lie like a pall on every surrounding object. So muffled and dark and still was this bit of primeval forest that no sign of life met us on the way; it seemed that with the passing of the Indian had passed the need for the little people of the wood; and yet, no doubt, bright, terror-stricken eyes were in every direction, watching the movements of the terrible and unaccountable enemy.

After long windings and turnings in the shadows, with no sign of the grass so necessary to our horses, we made our way to the banks of a tumbling torrent which seemed to come from the Lyell ice-fields. From the deathly silence of the forest, our serenade all that night was the rushing, pounding stream as it hurled itself along among the boulders of the river-bed scarce ten feet away. On each side of the very narrow valley avanaches had torn and ripped the trees from their roots in every direction, and amidst this havoc and desolation was the only feed our hungry horses could find, and very poor picking at that. As yet we had seen nothing of the lakes to which Outram had given the lovely name, the name which had lured us through those long, silent, weary hours in the deep, lonely forest.

In a rainy, misty sort of sunshine the next morning, we essayed a climb to look for the lakes. How hot it was when the sun beat down! How steep and tough the avalanche-scarred hillside! How bitter cold the wind from the ice-fields! And our reward, "the lakes like jewels," where were they? Toiling stubbornly onward to the bare cliffs above, we reached the loose unstable scree just beneath them, paused and looked eagerly to the valley below upon a chain of sloughs. Beautiful they were, too, lying in peaceful silence far below, like giant emeralds tossed there by mountain gnomes. From his height of several thousand feet above us the enthusiastic climber had beheld "lakes."

The home stretch lay over Howse and Baker Passes, the latter very beautiful but difficult to travel. It is hard, at best, to leave behind the days of freedom, the constantly shifting panorama of mountains, lakes and rivers, the balsam-laden air; to return to the beaten track, to four walls, and all the cares which know so well how to creep within them. It was a summer of almost continuous cold and storm, but with no accidents to ourselves or the horses. It was a happy sixteen weeks amidst as fine a cyclorama of changing scenery as the dear old world can offer, and there was always the sunshine of contentment and goodwill within the tent and at the camp-fire.

Please return. Meeting Mr James was a wonderful privilege. I and the only surviving 'Pioneer' in Canada.

Palliser's Expedition

SOME INTIMATE GLIMPSES

By MARY S. WARREN, Banff.

NOTHING is very small perspective is one of the Calgary papers in which this city regarding the work of Capt. Palliser, it seems to me the Rockies cub can do no better than at times refer to our very lusty history of the northwest. I am sure that you enjoyed reading it to Lady Hester, at Pretoria in Lower Hutt, Wellington, New Zealand where she resides with her daughter Margery.

STORY IS HARD TO FOLLOW

There are two copies of "Palliser's Journal" in Banff but at the present moment I have not access to them, though with Mr. Cameron I know of their presence. I have a print of this would buy a complete copy. The story of Capt. Palliser is very, very hard to follow as each member seemed to contribute something to the entire whole of his report. Perhaps Mr James Hector did the major part of it. I know Mr. Hector, on his coming of Dr. or later Sir James Hector, back to his old haunts of the 80's a great tragedy preventing the people of Canada knowing him personally.

At some of your meetings you might find the paper I write of interest. It was in 1904 I first met, at time an American citizen absolutely unfamiliar with any data I could obtain of those who had gone before in the most beautiful part of the world—the Canadian Rockies. There was a small inn at Glacier at the time, which was mainly used in feed the passengers on the Pacific cars the powerful engines of the present had not come into existence, by which to haul the present diners over the mountains as they do this existing.

ON THE HUNT FOR HIS GRAVE

I was sitting quietly in the small rotunda of the little hotel, sketching I think, when my eyes caught the remark: "I want to see my grave." Then could the professor scrap of a list on the counter of the office. One naturally takes an interest in anyone who is on the hunt of his own grave and as it happened I was the only anyone who had any history at his tongue's end, I slipped from my chair and quietly went to the desk to see if I could render anything aid. The charming hostess of many years standing was listening to a rather undersized and very emphatic just rather elegant gentleman, least 70, though later I wondered if his wish might not have aged him. Knowing my love of discovering historical people, she beckoned to me and introduced me to Mr. Hank, who takes some pleasure in this special quarter east of Cheyenne." I did not believe I gasped, but was politely astonished to discover I had come in touch with the fellow who actually had helped to write "Palliser's Journal" and who had done so much toward opening a part of the Rockies.

I lost no time Palliser's book at that time, and bearing in mind of it as politely as possible I asked where he meant to look for his grave. He seemed delighted to find someone who would be an interest in neighborhood travels and in a few minutes I was a happy listener. I cannot remember anything regarding his reading of the Palliser book of the Rockies, but we all know it was no easy journey no matter what route he took. Handing them peaches to where the pressure was being a very moving spirit in the expedition sent out by the English government to locate a route through Canada without having to forced to enter the U.S. They had come up with a party of Indians who seemed to have had some idea of their ancestors have made some were after this; some are they were not some to get into the land of plenty.

BECAME POWERFUL AS MEDICINE MAN

All the wheedling and coaxing will nothing brought but one answer: they could go no further. They had never been a most characteristic situation to men such as Palliser and his friends and they were merely stopping time as he thought that they should return to their country unhindered, or not. As Sir James expressed it to me: "We were certainly stuck." After a few days of delicate dysentery became rife in the Indian camp close by and they came to me for medicine. I had carried quite a lot of material from Kew Gardens in me and among the stuff I found exactly what was the most necessary thing to give them. Over I go and their ready to completely change the new quarters, insisted they use only water from a certain stream and specified my medicine be left behind. All the sick grew well in no time and I became a 'great medicine man.' Our troubles were over. After that the mountains were my friends and my guide I chose." From that point his story may be easily followed. his course is the present Cascade Mountain in Rocky Pass future stage, his following the same route I taken over Vermilion pass, etc., though he doubtless kept to the stream and all the way to Kicking Horse Valley, as his Indians had and followed as the case might be and eventually he came out somewhere about the present site of Kamloops. They took the lead of a river turning to the east. "But where was the grave for which you speak of looking."

"Oh, I meant to be that." They followed up the Kicking Horse river at now known, when they decided they saw better feeling on the other side. "I guessed they took the timber back of my pony, as caper was I to get over with the rest of our party. The party refused the will stream I guess they thought I had lost view on the camp. That was the last I knew till I woke in time to find a grave yawning for me. My friends had decided I was dead and they were doing the last respectful and gladdening my under the sod. This I stoutly refused and having recovered my wind, was ready to go off again up that wild stream.

SADNESS SHADOWED GREAT DISCOVERY

My men called that stream by the name it goes by at the present time and as you know I am fully convinced I you know I am fully convinced I you know I are fully convinced I that I was the first grave of mine." We had not known that the rivers in her ourselves was looking for the coming of the pioneer and by more chance we had found one in whom the history of our great west is so keenly interesting. Personally I had only climbed the most southern mountains at the time or followed very poor trails, but I was for after years take only from and history. In the strong sympathy he felt for the suffering his son was seemed to be suffering great pain. At last he called in my husband who instantly diagnosed it as appendicitis and after a delay instant arrived in the hospital at Revelstoke.

Sir James was an old man either in years or great exposure in youth or later but he was a frequent visitor Wellington, N.Z. He refused to think the other doctor's diagnosis was correct. There are other among physicians in which doubt was in step. I knew that night that Dr. Hank slept very uneasily and that morning I asked the reason. That my school had completed and that last night, I fear another 24 hours will be quite too late." Not being a doctor I was only a very primary girl who knew what I wanted and what I went for it. I descended the stairs to the main hall, made enquiry as to where Sir James was and in a very short time those in power had put the very sick boy on the train and hurried him and his dear father to the Revelstoke hospital. That we waited. Toward night came the telegram: "Twenty-four hours too late. We could not save him." Knowing the history of the brave old man, trying a little for the sake of the son, it did seem as though the lights of Glacier went out that night.

EDWARD WHYMPER ARRIVED COINCIDENTALLY

Edward Whymper, the first man to climb the Matterhorn, arrived the night on which we received the sad tidings. We found that in two days the boy, Douglas, was well enough to leave Revelstoke and his father would give up all further travelling and return to New Zealand by the same boat on which they had come to Vancouver. Through the courtesy of the western divisional superintendent, ourselves, Mr. Whymper and two people from Revelstoke were allowed to go to Revelstoke and be with the father when he had his boy to sleep.

We got there in time we were to take a freight to meeting Glacier at 5 a.m. We ate our breakfast in peke, always listening for the freight train. It arrived about 6 o'clock. The funeral was a fine one and it was just ten past 7 when we stepped from the train. It seemed very uneasy that an old and intimate friend of Sir James that had just arrived in Revelstoke from the Klondike so was ahead of us who would have done any kindness for him.

It was a small procession that wended its way on foot to the little cemetery at Revelstoke. A few years later I was to be weighed in sight of the old pioneer was laid gently in rest where he lies today—Douglas Hector. How many knew today that he is descendant of one of Capt. Palliser's best men lies in Revelstoke in a neglected grave? One thing I remember so very distinctly of which my mother-in-law, Lady Hester, said: "Did you hear of a place known as the Great Divide? I know I could find it. It was the highest point of the way over which we had to make our struggle up the Kicking Horse."

THE NAMING OF THE GREAT DIVIDE

We had been very much out of food and so reaching this place we divided a goose among our party and noticing a stream of water called it "the Great Divide." I do not think this is in Palliser's report but it was a story told me of the wonderful last of pioneers. When the water had been descended, I believe it is reported how some of the Hector party went forth some south to look for food, leaving the rest of the party of the ground that sturdy pioneer had covered, reported in a few years later that Palliser's report had traced at what that men alone did in that the Palliser expedition a success. It is strange to read in the report that after all their hard work, they could not be unanimously recommended to the British government to consider a trans-continental road feasible. It was a strange fate which brought that first man to the country and to find a calamity which took him home at once.

On the afternoon our little handful of friends—for grief makes the friends—gathered on the lawn of the Revelstoke hotel. Sir James had for the first time in his life met the man with whom he had long had correspondence—Edward Whymper, in trepidation I asked him if he felt he was worthy of the great pioneer and his famous friend. "He immediately consented as did Mr. Whymper and I value those pictures very highly. That night the invalid and man returned to his home and home to his home.

Later I was to learn that many of my friends on the C.P.R. had been waiting for his coming. It was not to be.

Kind Sir, Yours truly, Mary S. Warren. Mr. Campbell Mills, 1 Ft. Ave. Banff. Alta. Can. Will stop by for specimens to hand or transcribe.